



MONTHLY UPDATE

Zimbabwe: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-08 • 54 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • FINANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • DIGITALISATION • TECHNOLOGY
• CAPACITY • INCLUSION • DATA • GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

A five-year artificial-intelligence strategy arrived complete with its own institutions. The launch on 4 August [named a regulatory sandbox and a supervising council](#), and [an innovation fund and a grand challenge alongside a national data commons](#) — four bodies announced on one day, none of them yet carrying a budget, a constituting instrument or an opening date on this ledger.

The applied end of the same technology is already running on the roads: [artificial-intelligence traffic cameras are being expanded nationwide](#), with no data-protection authorisation, retention rule or contest route recorded for the footage. Data protection itself is being priced rather than enforced: doctors [object to the levies under the data-controller licensing regime](#) and civil society [warns that certification fees will exclude rural communities and young women](#), with mandatory compliance inspections due to begin on 1 September. The anti-corruption commission meanwhile [is investigating cyber-enabled fraud in the vehicle licensing, mobile airtime and revenue authority systems](#) — fraud inside the state's own digital estate, named system by system.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The ICT ministry committed on 29 July to an artificial-intelligence ethics framework tabled by the end of the first quarter of 2027, publishing neither a standard nor a compliance deadline ([launch account](#)).

On children online the country has taken the policy route where its neighbours have taken the legislative one. Zimbabwe [has adopted a policy covering cyber-harassment, sextortion and data protection](#), while Gabon has fixed digital majority at 16 by ordinance with platform design duties attached and Rwanda is preparing a restriction on under-16s. The policy text and its adoption date are not held, only a comparative account of it, and no instrument, supervisory body or enforcement action is on record — which is the distinction the comparison turns on, since the constraint reported across the region is enforcement rather than law.

Legislation and regulation

The regulator ran a notice in the press on 26 July setting mandatory data-protection inspections from 1 September 2026, with a registration threshold of 50 data subjects, licence fees in four tiers, a US\$30 application fee, and journalistic, historical and archival processing exempt from the Act but still required to register ([notice account](#)).

The justice minister told the Senate on 23 July that government has begun implementing the third constitutional amendment, transferring voter registration and management of the roll from the electoral commission to the registrar-general, and characterised the 2013 transfer to the commission as a response to legacy issues now considered resolved; no date, transition plan or safeguard was stated ([Senate account](#)).

Data protection

Certification of every data protection officer is required under the same 26 July notice, at US\$1,250 for a Zimbabwean ([notice account](#)).

August brought the objections. Healthcare providers and the medical association [objected to the data-controller licensing regime as applied to them](#) – roughly US\$300 a year plus a mandatory data protection officer – [calling it costly and duplicative of existing health-professions regulation](#) ahead of the September inspections, and a published analysis [argued the regulator's threshold-based licensing model is disproportionately burdensome for small entities](#) against the risk-based approach of the European regulation it is compared with. The statutory instrument's fee schedule is not held, and no licence count, exemption or regulator response to the objections is on record.

Two further protection questions surfaced without a regulator attached. The anti-corruption commission is [investigating cyber-enabled fraud across three state digital systems](#): suspected manipulation of the driver-licensing platform, a US\$150m diversion of state mobile-operator airtime with a criminal case pending and asset forfeiture completed, and a scheme crediting more than ZiG55m and US\$260,000 of fictitious prepayments on the revenue authority's customs platform. And the National Child Online Protection Policy 2026-2030, [approved by Cabinet in June, has no reporting route, responder training or funded rollout on record](#) – which is what a published analysis argues will decide whether it protects anyone.

The government put the national data volume at [179 petabytes against 114 previously](#) and cited the near-doubling in telling technology firms that corporate responsibility is not negotiable, resting the point on the National Child Online Protection Policy approved by Cabinet in June. Separately, civil-society organisations say [data-protection certification fees are high enough to exclude rural communities and young women](#) from compliance; no fee schedule, exemption or regulator response is on file. The base had been carrying that child-protection policy as three separate rows, minted from three separate reports; they are now resolved to one.

The approval date itself is now settled from the primary record: the Office of the President and Cabinet's own briefing dates approval to the [Seventeenth Cabinet Meeting of 2 June 2026, and sets out nine strategic focus areas from institutional capacity and legal framework through technical control and corporate responsibility to monitoring and learning, aligned to the Constitution and the Children's Act, with legislation carrying enforceable sanctions to follow](#). The base had been carrying 10 July 2026, which is the policy's Bulawayo launch.

Regional collaboration

A Rwandan immigration delegation toured two border posts on 29 July under a 2024 bilateral memorandum ([visit account](#)).

Harare then hosted the regional attempt to write common rules for the thing all these systems run on. Southern African regulators, data-protection authorities and artificial-intelligence task forces [met for a three-day workshop to harmonise national data-governance rules](#), anchored to the African Union data policy framework, a continental data governance blueprint, the regional data strategy and a UNESCO toolkit, with the convening body noting that only 1% of data-centre capacity sits within Africa. No outcome document, commitment or timetable from it is held.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Planning moved a generation further out. The ICT ministry's permanent secretary was [appointed to the parliamentary body planning a thirty-year national roadmap to 2056](#), which the ministry presents as putting the sector at the centre of long-term national planning. No terms of reference, membership list, work programme or output for the committee is held, and the roadmap itself does not yet exist - so what is established is a seat at a table, not a plan.

Finance

New investments

The ICT minister also committed on 29 July to ring-fencing a share of the universal services fund for public-good artificial-intelligence projects, stating no amount ([launch account](#)).

Two external commitments arrived in August, and only one of them has a number attached to Zimbabwe. A United Nations contract award of 10 August [puts US\\$5,947,948 into the supply of ICT equipment to the country](#) – an exact figure against a purpose stated as nothing more than ICT equipment, with neither the receiving government body nor the awarded vendor named. The United Kingdom separately [opened expressions of interest for a Southern Africa science and technology accelerator worth up to GBP2.5m to March 2030](#), naming Zimbabwe and Zambia as its first year's focus with South Africa the primary one. No Zimbabwean allocation is stated and no delivery consortium has been chosen.

A third is a conversation. The President met a delegation from an emirate government and a technology company at State House on 8 August to [explore a digitisation partnership for aviation and border security](#), aimed at modernising immigration and border-management systems. Talks only, and no instrument, value, scope or data-protection provision is stated for systems that would process traveller data.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Phase 1 of the cross-border fibre corridor from Plumtree to Bulawayo was reported live and carrying traffic on 3 July 2026, at an initial equipped capacity of 800 Gbps on equipment rated above 10 Tbps; phase 2 to Livingstone is due in September 2026 ([corridor account](#)).

The listed infrastructure company reported for the quarter ended May 2026 that it deployed 90 new base stations and reinvested 17% of revenue into capital projects on an undisclosed revenue base ([trading update](#)).

The state fixed operator's chief executive told its annual general meeting on 26 June that government arrears had risen to close to US\$42m, also given as ZiG1.2bn, from US\$19.2m a year earlier ([annual general meeting account](#)). The state mobile operator terminated its chief executive's contract on 4 August following a board resolution ([termination account](#)).

The state incumbent [set a target of connecting 114,000 homes to fibre](#), positioning the offer against satellite and private fibre competitors on price and speed. No timetable, current connection count or tariff accompanies the target.

Data Storage

The ICT ministry's 29 July address named a national high-performance computing centre, the state fixed operator and a private operator's data centre — the listed infrastructure company's Harare technology park among them — as the infrastructural spine for future government artificial intelligence ([launch account](#)).

Against that argument for a national spine, the country's largest operator moved the other way. It says it has [fully migrated its operations, mobile money and telecommunications infrastructure included, off on-premise computing and private data centres onto Google Cloud, and intends to sell cloud services on to local enterprises next](#), citing resilience, continuity and faster feature deployment. No migration date, workload split, contract term or data-residency arrangement is published, and nothing in the base records a regulator's position on the country's mobile money platform running on infrastructure sited and operated elsewhere.

Energy

The listed infrastructure company commenced phase 1 of a 100 MW solar farm for its technology park, and its fuel-management system was credited with reducing energy consumption on tower sites, with no percentage, litre, cost or uptime figure given ([trading update](#)).

Cybersecurity

The national incident response team is named in the ICT ministry's own priority projects and has no completion date or operating status attached. The international project record behind it [carries an empty status field and an achievements field still stating it will be updated on completion](#), for a project that ran from July 2017 to February 2021. What is new is the first-party statement: the [ministry lists establishment of the team among its seven priorities](#), aimed at monitoring, detecting and responding to cyber threats.

DPI

Data Exchange

Customs data crossed a border on paper this month, in the form of an agreement to stop it having to. Customs administrations from five countries [adopted a roadmap and action plan for customs-to-customs data exchange at a meeting in Pretoria ending 26 August, to exchange trade information before consignments reach the border so that documentation and risk assessment happen earlier](#), building on a link this country already runs with Zambia. Data standards, interoperability, cybersecurity, legal authority and information quality are all recorded as unresolved, and no corridor or target crossing time is named.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A deputy registrar general told a meeting of African registrars general on 24 July that electronic passport enrolment centres operate in ten districts, eight provincial centres and one abroad, with seven-day issuance away from the capital ([meeting account](#)).

The registration end of the same estate is being rebuilt with donor money. [Ten civil registry sub-offices across eight districts are being computerised, digitalised and solar-powered under a China-funded project with UNICEF](#), to widen birth-registration access in underserved communities through mobile registration and outreach alongside existing water, sanitation and nutrition platforms. No value, timetable, district list or birth-registration baseline is stated, so there is nothing to measure the effect against.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The road authority took handover of an expanded toll plaza on 29 July with two of six lanes reserved for radio-frequency tag holders, a second plaza due the next day and a third under construction, against a stated programme covering all 29 tollgates; the announcement states nothing on retention, access or legal basis for the movement record the tags generate ([handover account](#)).

The switch operator reported interoperable quick-response payments in rollout and participation in a pan-African settlement system, with no merchant, acceptance-point or transaction count ([conference account](#)).

The quarter's own numbers came from the central bank rather than from a conference platform. Its report for the quarter ending 30 June puts [electronic transactions at ZiG757.12bn, up 23.71% on the first quarter, on 265.7 million transactions, with real-time gross settlement carrying 67.00% of the value and mobile money 12.96% of it on 236.67 million of the transactions](#) — the same split the base has carried since the fourth quarter of 2025, of a system whose value moves through settlement and whose use is almost entirely mobile.

Acceptance also widened from outside. A commercial bank and an international card scheme [opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards to participating merchants in nine African markets including Zimbabwe on 19 August](#), settling in local currency, US dollars or both; the merchant count is given for the nine markets together and not for Zimbabwe.

Registries

The same registrars-general meeting heard that all ten provinces and 63 districts are computerised for civil registration but only more than 20 of 209 sub-offices ([meeting account](#)).

The voters' roll transfer moved from statement to operation. On 18 August [the civil registry department and the electoral commission began a nationwide joint handover of voter registration and roll management to the registrar-general, provincial and district officers of both bodies meeting in Harare to work out how](#), under the constitutional amendment signed earlier in the year. No completion date, transition plan or safeguard has been stated at either end of the month.

Sectoral management information systems

The national electronic medical record reached [1,254 of a planned 1,900 health facilities](#), on a health financing partner's account rather than the ministry's. The [platform's own front page describes it as the national health operating system](#), spanning care-finding, provider verification, medicines and diagnostics directories, virtual care, an assistant and public health notices — run largely without a citizen account and gated by a separate professional-authority check — and carries no facility-coverage figure and no last-updated date of its own. An operator separately reports [more than 20 telehealth centres established](#), company-reported to an anniversary feature with no patient, consultation or availability figure.

On land the state consolidated rather than built: the lands minister said on 24 August that [three land databases had been merged into one integrated digital system reached through a One Stop Title Processing Centre, with 27,045 plots surveyed and 10,231 mapped to beneficiaries and 1,824 agreements of sale worth about US\\$110 million concluded](#). The figures are the implementation committee's own and nothing on this ledger tests them.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

An implementing partner reported on 28 July that it had been building artificial-intelligence competency among research, committee and budget-office staff in Zimbabwe's Parliament, and that staff were using public tools on personal judgment, with limited monitoring of data flows into those platforms and no consistent approach to identifying fabricated output ([partner account](#)).

The same capacity gap shows in the state's own books. The Auditor-General found that [only 26 local authorities submitted their 2024 financial statements on time, while the revenue authority pushes businesses onto its fiscalisation data management system](#) — a reporting failure inside government that the revenue drive does not address. The denominator of local authorities is not given in the record held, so the share filing on time cannot be stated.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The base's first evidence on the subnational tier is one council's own statement. Kwekwe City Council [bills rates, refuse, sewerage and water centrally through a municipal resource-planning package, each property carrying a unique account number and tariff code](#), and names information technology and e-governance among its finance department's five key functions. No user count, collection rate or digital-channel adoption figure is published, and nothing establishes the council as representative of other local authorities.

Rural digital data capture

The ICT minister told the National Assembly on 17 July that the universal services fund currently covers satellite-kit subscriptions only for digital centres and schools, and only for one year ([National Assembly account](#)).

Schools are where the terminals have gone. The education minister told the Senate that [11,500 satellite terminals have been distributed to schools — 8,000 to those with no wireless network and 3,500 to those already connected — with more than 1,300 institutions still to reach and a target of internet connectivity, solar power and national-grid access at every school by December 2026](#), alongside a cabinet commitment of 3% of GDP to research and innovation. The counts and the target are the minister's own; no school total, verification of installed and working terminals, or recurrent connectivity cost is stated — and the same fund that bought them pays a subscription for one year only.

Technology

AI

The same 29 July address committed to indigenous-language corpora work led by universities ([launch account](#)).

The listed infrastructure company described its remote monitoring system and digital twin as advancing rather than in production for the quarter ended May 2026 ([trading update](#)).

The first indigenous-language models in service are commercial rather than national. The dominant operator's artificial-intelligence subsidiary [is phasing in a Ndebele-speaking customer-support assistant from September, trained on thousands of hours of recorded Ndebele speech, alongside a Shona assistant it says already resolves more than 70% of enquiries](#). The resolution rate is the operator's own, and no dataset, evaluation, error rate or escalation route is published. What matters for the record is where the corpora sit: outside the indigenous-language programme the state has committed to and whose ring-fenced share is still unstated.

ICT Industry

A locally built enterprise platform was [formally launched at a university technology expo on 30 July](#), its developer already carrying systems across 83 local authorities and government projects including a mines export permit system and the citizen engagement platform. It is the base's clearest instance of Zimbabwean-written software at national scale; no licence value, contract or user figure is stated.

Innovation ecosystem

The same institute's [innovation hub hosted a three-day expo from 28 to 30 July](#) with an anticipated 10,000 participants, and carries a technopreneurship centre and a new centre for artificial intelligence. It follows the [presidential commissioning on 27 July of a university industrial incubation centre supporting 11 start-ups](#) across agriculture, ICT, engineering, pharmaceuticals, health, transport and energy. Attendance is the organisers' own expectation rather than a count.

Capacity

Training and skills

The artificial-intelligence grand challenge opened on 4 August [across agriculture, health, education, financial services, mining and public administration](#), and was stated as a recurring programme. The regulator reported [738 applications received and 68 projects selected for a boot camp in Nyanga, narrowed to 18 candidates for the next stage](#). No award, prize or budget has been published against any of it.

Inclusion

Access to services

The health minister told the National Assembly on 17 July that more than 400 health facilities had received satellite kits with 300 more to be added, but that subscriptions had not been paid because the fees were too high ([National Assembly account](#)).

At a payments conference on 24 July a research firm reported that 95% of transport payments remain cash, that 56% of respondents found digital systems complicated with people with disabilities particularly affected ([conference account](#)).

A media institute's August review sets the country's headline connectivity figure against what it costs. It records [internet penetration at 84.55% on the regulator's fourth-quarter 2025 data, many households spending more than 10% of income to be online against the United Nations' 2% benchmark, and only 62% of the population with reliable electricity](#), and asks whether the 2026-2030 artificial-intelligence strategy can be delivered on those foundations. The penetration figure counts active subscriptions rather than individual users, which is the gap the affordability finding sits in.

A larger round of the regulator's disability training ran, and it reached teachers rather than learners: [a five-day workshop at Chiredzi for 37 teachers with visual impairments and their assistants and aides, drawn from all ten provinces, covering assistive technologies and accessible digital platforms](#), facilitated with the same civil-society internet chapter as the June cohort. The Act that would give any of this a statutory footing was passed in November 2025 and still awaits commencement.

Data

National statistics

The 2025 household survey, released on 20 July, reported household internet access at 75.5% against 50.1% in 2020, mobile handset ownership at 96.4%, and household computer ownership down to 11.2% from 14.2%, at 21.2% urban against 4.7% rural ([survey account](#)).

Open data

A [national data commons was announced on 4 August](#) for public institutions, industry and researchers to share anonymised datasets, with selected government datasets stated to become publicly accessible within six months. No governing rule, dataset list or portal is held.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

Zimbabwe withdrew from the bilateral health talks, and the dispute over why was settled this month against the templates rather than the parties. Harare's account is that talks ended over long-term United States access to national health data and an attempt to fold in critical minerals; the [embassy stated the conditions were co-investment, financial accountability and specimen sharing during outbreaks, and that assertions it sought Zimbabweans' personal data are categorically false](#). Both are supportable. The [model data-sharing agreement gives the United States secure, uninterrupted access, expressly including login credentials, to seven national health systems for twenty-five years continuing ten years past termination](#) — and in the same clause tells the partner not to provide individual-level or personally identifiable data unless there is no other way. The [template memorandum requires physical specimens and related genetic sequence data of pathogens with epidemic potential within five days of detection, for twenty-five years](#). Harare is describing standing credentialled access to live systems; Washington is denying transfer of identifiable records. Neither template is the Zimbabwe draft, which was never signed and does not exist as a public document. [About 1.2m people on United States-supported HIV treatment face wind-down](#).

China activities

A Harare forum [argued that cooperation with China will help African countries build technological capability](#), with the terms of technology transfer the point at issue. The account is carried by Chinese state media, which is part of what it evidences. No project, transfer arrangement or commitment is named in it, so it records an argument about the relationship rather than a movement within it.

Gulf/UAE activities

The Emirati minister of state [met the President in Harare on 10 August to discuss economy, investment and trade](#). No agreement was announced, which is the movement: the two governments had [agreed in Dubai in February to conclude a comprehensive economic partnership agreement within three months](#), and August is three months past that deadline.

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